Introduction

Video games lend themselves particularly well to the analysis of liminality (Horrigan, 2021; Jiao 2024), of thresholds stretched into tunnels (Turner, 1974: 72). The scientific attraction to the deterritorialisation of the experience, the invisible link that connects players to games, allows great freedom in terms of non-standard discoveries. To work on the relationship with the Other, i.e., with the unfamiliar, the surprising and the unknown, it is on this invisible thread that efforts must be focused, since to isolate the Other is to focus on something that cannot be known; it is to write or read an impossible world, because it would necessitate the text to be in a vacuum, disconnected from any familiar thing. To avoid an alien explanation, it is possible to turn to phenomenological studies, particularly those of Merleau-Ponty, because they allow us to relate to the Other horizontally, meaning that the Other is not an object, but is linked to the Self by a network of intersubjectivity. The invisible that we seek to explain is vertically organised, in the depth of the flesh that is beyond the intelligible and re-emerges through affects that one can be conscious of (Mazis, 2016; Merleau-Ponty, 1968). This paper therefore does not directly study the invisible, but instead attempts to generalise the differences, the Otherness, that make one feel the invisible. This leads to the study of liminal affects which bring contradictory categories as soon as we try to describe them. The present paper explores the experience of Otherness to theorise these liminal affects.

For this project, an ontological framework, a set of narrative analysis tools, and an analysis of *Inside* (Playdead, 2016) are proposed so the reader can situate, operate and experience the concepts mobilised. To make understanding easier, the explanations are triplicated as far as possible, i.e. the same ideas are reformulated ontologically, phenomenologically and poetically, corresponding, respectively, to the ontological layers of institutions[1], embodied experiences and fictions (Figure 1). This structure allows the grouping and application of theories from different disciplines for a political analysis of video games.

[1] Institutions are defined as 'complex social forms that reproduce themselves such as governments, the family, human languages, universities, hospitals, business corporations, and legal systems' (Miller 2024, np)

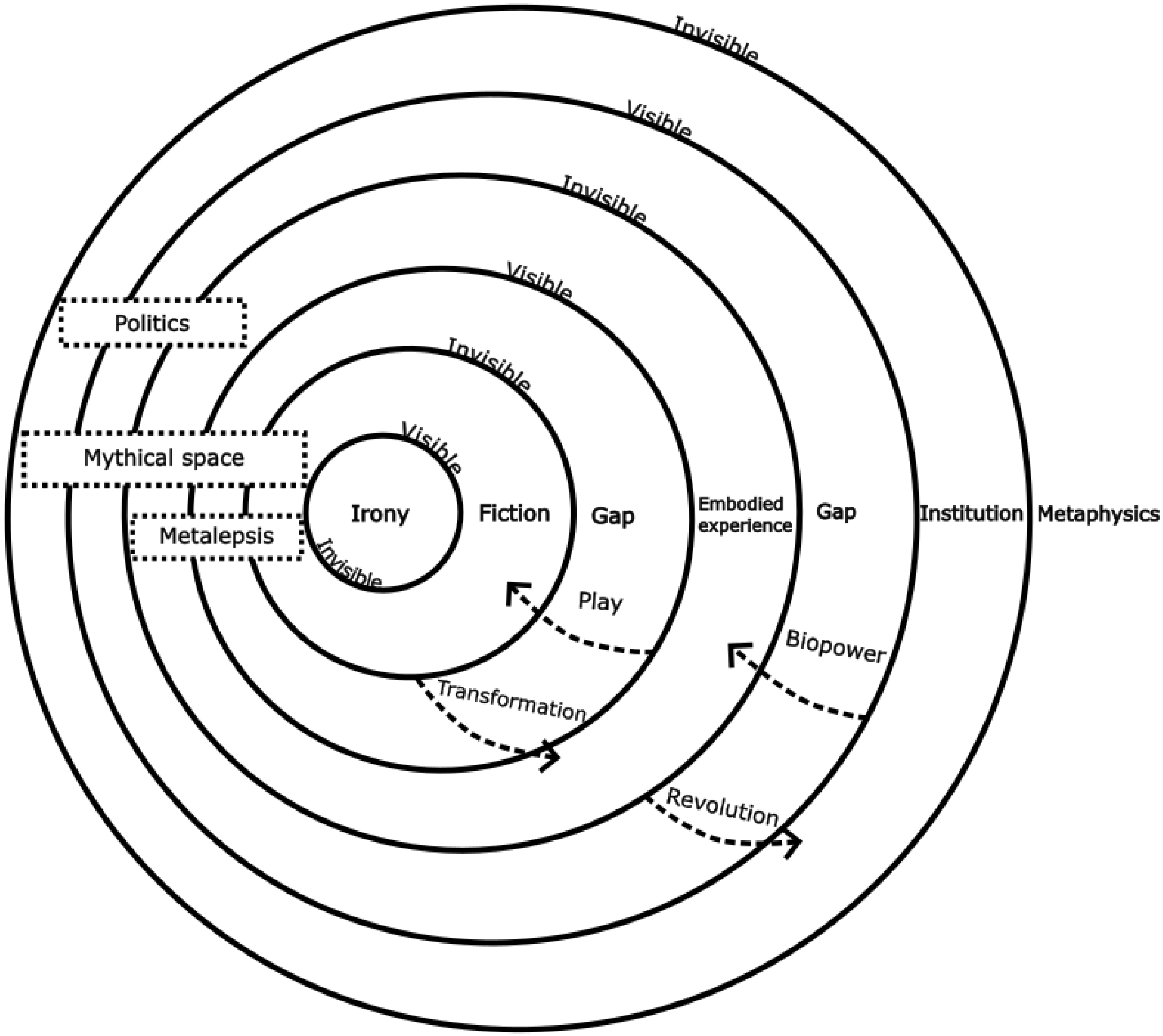

Figure 1: Schematic representation of the ontological layers

1. Ontological Context

This section focuses on the ontological situation of metaleptic fiction based on phenomenological approaches to fiction and institutions, centring around actual lived experiences. The present paper's primary axiom—foundational belief—is the existence and necessity of the Self, the Other, and the World, as the chosen solid ground for research and are thus capitalised—a sacralisation that can be compared with panentheism although this is not explored here.

1.1. Moral Edges of Existence: Hope and Faith

Before the detailed definition of the Self-World-Other ontological framework, the moral purpose of such a definition is explained, i.e., how it turns the question ‘What makes people play games?’ into ‘Do games transform people?’.

The question ‘What makes people play games?’ contains the immanent, visible, and hierarchised components of the Self-World-Other framework divided into three ontological layers—institution, embodied reality, and fiction—that can be defined from top to bottom. The ‘What’ exists in the institutional layer; it has the power to ‘make people’, i.e., to organise their lives through biopower (see Hardt and Negri, 2000), and here it organises the people’s life towards the activity of play. The ‘people’ exist in the embodied reality layer—the actual world—and their ‘play’ is what constitutes ‘games’ on the fictional layer. Institutions create a ‘subworld’ (see Wolf, 2012) in which people exist and in turn create a sub-subworld: the game world.

However, it is not always clear that ‘play’ creates games; it is arguably an analogue to a myth-ritual situation. Myth-ritual theory is not unified, but their interest in the link between myth and ritual (Segal, 2011: 69)—similar to the link between game and play—is common. For Bascom (1957), there is no definitive answer to know

> whether a myth is (1) a narrative which is recited as a part of a ritual, (2) a narrative, the events of which are enacted in a ritual, (3) a narrative which is both recited and enacted in a ritual, or (4) a narrative which is only indirectly and secondarily associated with ritual (Bascom, 1957: 113-114).

If like in Bascom’s case (3), games are considered the root of play, then it is possible to study how the ontological layers organise themselves from bottom to top. The resulting question is ‘Do games make people transform their institutions?’ or in a contracted form ‘Are games political?’. While answering this question is beyond the present paper’s scope, defending the idea that games can shape people, i.e., asking ‘Do games transform people?’, arguably has the same ethical foundation as defending that people can shape their institutions.

While the top-to-bottom movement is motivated by faith, the bottom-to-top movement is motivated by hope. Rorty (1989) establishes two figures, the liberal metaphysician and the liberal ironist, who disagree on how they justify their political struggle for freedom (84). The former grounds his motivation for society's transformation for the better on the faith towards an entity beyond institutions; a faith that is the absolute ground for our reality. The latter does not believe that there is any absolute grounding for reality but finds it useful to pretend to hope for an amelioration of society. In other words, while the metaphysicist believes in an *invisible ontological layer beyond 'institution'*, the ironist believes in the usefulness of the movement triggered by the hopes existing in an *invisible ontological layer under 'fiction'*. This opposition between two invisible realms will be explored again in the section on wonder when comparing Levinas's and Merleau-Ponty's conceptions of 'face'.

Thus, 'Do games transform people?' is a question that implies an ironist perspective. Although the movement from one ontological layer can be explained in both directions, their hierarchy remains the same for it could otherwise lead to the conclusion that dying in a video game is as important as dying in real life (Horrigan, 2021). Video games are people's subworlds, they are not embodied beings, but neither are they deprived of agency. To study the agency of games is to study the power of ontologically inferior entities.

1.2. The Self the World and the Other

I consider there to be three interdependent realms of existence: the meaningful, the social, and the material (Oprisko, 2012: 44) where activities and dangers concern the Self the Other and the World. If these realms are not sustained, and in the case of human beings, they lead to suicide, marginalisation, and biological death. Following the same model as the Chinese concept of 'face', these modes of existence are things that one can only lose, and not accumulate or win, but only earn and maintain (Hu, 1944). These modes are observable and analysable during liminal interactions: for instance, the social interaction—between the Self and the Other—can be observed as *rite de passage*, transformative experiences of the Self through a temporary union of the Self with the Other and the emergence of *communitas* through *anti-structures* (Turner, 1974: 75).

Merleau-Ponty's phenomenology accounts for a monistic and holistic approach to reality (Strasser, 1986: 502)—as space, time and truths—most accurately described with the concepts of *fluidity, multiplicity, and situatedness*. The categories of Self, Other and World are to be understood as perspectives and attitudes towards an object of study. A human being is Self when focusing on the flow of consciousness—through time—(Merleau-Ponty, 1945: 485), Other when taken in its multiplicity—of truths—(Merleau-Ponty, 1945: 85), and World when situated in a system (in space) giving functions (Merleau-Ponty, 1945: 279). For Merleau-Ponty, subjectivity *is* time (Merleau-Ponty, 1945: 483), it is the continuous identity through an ever-evolving time, as opposed to a Husserlian conception of *Abschattungen* in which identity changes at every point in time (Merleau-Ponty, 1945: 479). This division of human identity is clearly expressed through the concept of ipseity, the identity through time, and idem, the identity at a given time (see Ricoeur, 1990: 12). The Self is thus constructed as fluid, in the sense used by Bauman (2000), as opposed to solid:

> [S]olids cancel time; for liquids, on the contrary, it is mostly time that matters. … Description of fluids are all snapshots, and they need a date at the bottom of the picture (Bauman, 2000: 2).

For Merleau-Ponty, the most exhaustive description of existence is in the 'things themselves'. He gives the following illustration:

> [T]he house itself is not the house seen from nowhere, but the house seen from everywhere. The completed object is translucent, being shot through from all sides by an infinite number of present scrutinies which intersect in its depths leaving nothing hidden. (Merleau-Ponty, 2006: 79)

This illustration is the basis for both multiplicity and situatedness. The necessity of multiplicity, i.e., Otherness in the form of difference, is established by Deleuze (1994: 182) as follows: '[i]nstead of the enormous opposition between the one and the many, there is only the variety of multiplicity - in other words, difference'.

It is impossible to not be situated. For phenomenologists, one is conscious *of* something, being is always being-*with*, or being-*in* (Matthew 2006; Keogh 2023). This does not mean that it is completely impossible, to transcend a condition or to innovate, but, rather, that emergence can only happen during ‘travels’, a notion developed in sections 1.3. and 2.1..

1.3. Wonder of the Other

Social existence is not limited to the alterity of other human beings. It is through language, gestures, and rituals with another human being that the Self exists socially. To extend the experience of Otherness to non-living things—and *a fortiori* non-human beings—like video games, it is necessary to be interested in Lévinas’s (1998) concept of ‘face’, defined as 'the site of the gestures of the entire silent world of myriad beings' (Mazis, 2016: 104). This posthuman social existence requires a 'relaxing [of] our hold on the world in order for matter and objects to generate their own performative activity' (Onishi, 2023: 35). Onishi assimilates this process to enchantment (ibid.), defined as follows:

> *[E]nchantment* entails a state of wonder, and one of the distinctions of this state is the temporary suspension of chronological time and bodily movement. To be enchanted, then, is to participate in a momentarily immobilizing encounter (Bennett, 2001: 5).

The posthuman social existence fostered by the solo video game experience leads to reasoning where wonder plays a central role, as the silent experience of Otherness.

In poetic terms, for a thing to exist 'it is not necessary to live, it is necessary to travel' (Burroughs, 1986: 149). What it means in the present paper’s ontological framework is that existence happens in the liminal space between two ontological realms. Thus, there are three types of travel: *expression* between the World and the Self, *ritual* between the Self and the Other, and *system* between the Other and the World. Each of these travels has two poles, one fostering stability and the other instability. On the stable side, expression is 'pure repetition' (Landes, 2013: 4), ritual is 'normative social structure' (Turner, 1974: 59), and a system is 'self-organisation' (Rietveld et al., 2018: 52), whereas on the unstable side, expression is 'pure creation' (Landes, 2013: 4), ritual is 'anti-structure' (Turner, 1974: 65), and a system is 'emergence' (Bich, 2006:

284)—in an enactivist cognitive approach (see Di Paolo 2018). Rather than continuing with a detailed explanation of these modes of transport—which would be beyond the scope of the present paper—it is possible to find some unifying characteristics between them through the concept of wonder. Omitting the stable sides, these travels can be represented as follows (Figure 2):

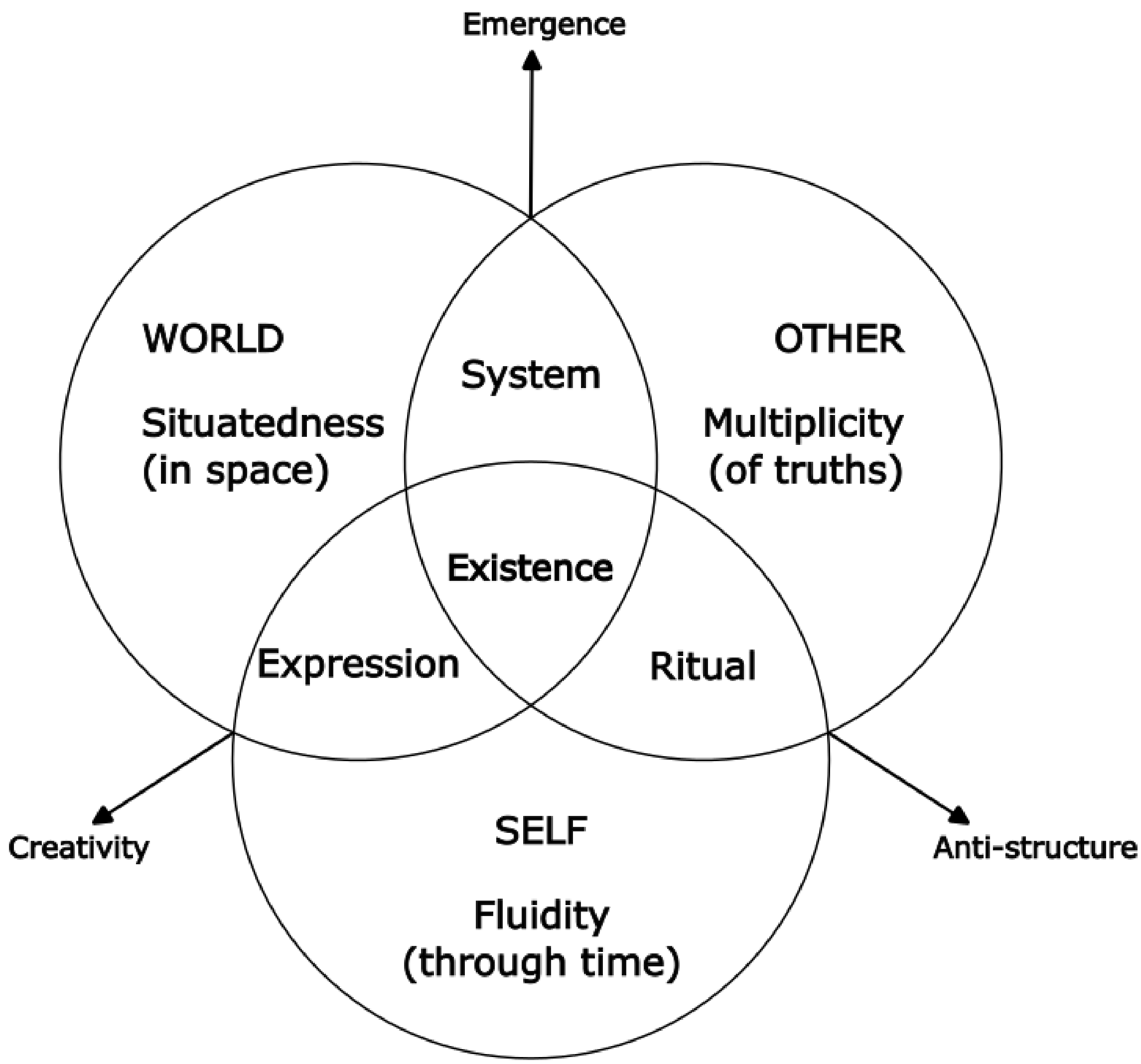

Figure 2: Travel and instability between the Self, the World, and the Other

Onishi (2023) makes the distinction between epistemic and ontological wonder. Wonder in general acts as a motor that pulls the Self from one state to another, it is the beginning, the spark that starts transformation. For epistemic wonder, it triggers questioning and inquiry in the sense of Dewey (1938) (Thievenaz, 2016). It focuses on the revelation of ignorance, destabilising what one counts as acquired. Ontological wonder is considered 'passive' (Thievenaz, 2016: 19), for it is not mobilising an intellectual process and escapes the usual instrumentalisation of wonder (Onishi, 2023: 65). Rather, it plays a role in the existence of Otherness and is convincingly analysed through Levinas's concept of face and its Pontian acceptation (Mazis, 2016).

The opposition between Levinas and Merleau-Ponty's conceptions of face relies on the ontological gap between the Self and the Other. For Levinas, this gap is metaphysical; it escapes our time and space and presents a breach outside of ourselves (Levinas, 1998: 91). For Merleau-Ponty, this gap is a return to the pre-reflexive state, an opening to 'an intercorporeal being, a presumptive domain of the visible and the tangible, which extends further than the things I touch and see at present' (Merleau-Ponty, 1968: 142-143); the opening to the depth of one's flesh (Mazis, 2016: 105). For the latter, the experience of the Other uncovers the 'things as they are' taken in their totality, bonding beings together. This experience of Otherness is not limited to humans, but also to unconscious things, thus entailing a

> decentering from the anthropocentric vision of the philosophical and Western cultural tradition that asserts that humans express our unique ability to grasp the world in language as its source of meaning (Mazis, 2016: 300).

Ethical conclusions about Levinas's call for 'hospitality and sacrifice for the sake of the Other' (Mazis, 2016: 102) make it clear that it is the rise to awareness of the gap between beings, of the boundaries of the 'natural standpoint' (Schmidt 1985, 22)—the post-reflexive state—that allows an ambivalent understanding of the Self-Other relationship. More poetically, this extended conception of the relationship to otherness can be found in love:

> One finds love through the aspects of oneself and the other that are grounded in perception, but must be imaginatively brought into discovery and expression. The aspects of both persons emerging through the perceptual and expressive interchange with the other give rise to the myth that traces out a shared destiny. This myth allows us to care, to confront, and to discover together the creative possibilities of how we may bring ourselves to mutuality (Mazis, 2016: 213).

On an affective level, wonder is felt through liminal affects, opening the 'fascinating/repulsive, creative/destructive, astounding/horrifying, heirophanic/monstrous [sic] excess' (Rubenstein, 2006: 13) and revealing the gaps in the categories one uses to understand the world. For example, the uncanny felt at the sight of a monster reveals a creature that is the 'natural form of the unnatural' (Foucault, 2003: 56); such contradiction in wonder can also be found in childhood through make-believe games (Caillois, 1958; Sutton-Smith 1999) as ‘unbelieved beliefs’, or in nostalgia as the 'present of the past' (Augustine cited in Ricoeur, 1983: 37). The study of unnatural narratives and devices that foster this kind of affects thus constitutes an appropriate scope for exploring wonder in technical terms.

2. Narrative Analysis of the Avatar

Metalepsis is an unnatural narrative device that makes it possible to analyse in-depth ontological wonder in video games. It is first necessary to translate the notions from ontology into fictional study terms to then analyse metaleptic devices, and thus wonder, in video games.

2.1. Ontology and Narratology

In the study of the relationship between reality and fiction, different theories draw the boundary between the two and change what counts as play or not. There is a spectrum of theories about the experience of fiction, from the totalisation of reality into fiction, or representation, as in Goffman’s (1956) and Baudrillard’s (1981) work, but also in Suits (1978) where make-believe is also an everyday game, or Carse (1986) where the boundaries of the game are played with by 'infinite players', spiritually guiding their lives. This set of theories allows one to explore reality through a game studies lens, i.e., everyday life as a game. At the other end of the spectrum, one finds the theories about extraordinary spaces, meaning that fiction is separated from everyday life by a ‘magic circle’, a term coined by Huizinga (1998: 20) to express that the border delimiting the game space is the same as the Durkheimian boundary separating the sacred from the profane. This whole spectrum of theories reflects multiple approaches to Merleau-Ponty’s mythical space; one accepts everyday life as composed of myths, accentuating the openness and permeability of the mythical consciousness (Merleau-Ponty, 1945: 338); the other accepts the ontological difference between fiction and reality, which does not mean that the boundary is the same for everyone but that there *is* an enunciable one. The movement from one end of the spectrum to the other can be described through the theories of ontological metalepsis (Bell, 2016) and magical realism (Thiem, 2000). Transport is also described by theories of make-believe where it is not the world that is fluid, but the identity of the player who immerses herself through make-believe games as in Walton (1980; 1993) and Evans (1982).

If theories of make-believe focus on the player's side of the experience of fiction, metalepsis theories focus on the game's side. They analyse how characters, the fictional subjects of experience, relate to players, the actual subjects of experience. This parallel has been drawn by Pavel as follows:

> Caught up in the story, Walton's spectator projects a fictional ego that takes part in the imaginary happenings; symmetrically, Ryan's author impersonates a fictional speaker or writer who fully belongs to the imaginary world and in this capacity introduces the fictional beings and states of affairs to the fictional ego of the reader. (Pavel, 1986: 88)

The ontological gap is best translated through Pavel's notion of *distance* (1986) and the study of unnatural narratives through the degree of estrangement or defamiliarisation. Unnatural narrative is a term used to describe any narration that relates something not physically or logically possible in our actual world. That said, our conception and knowledge of the possible is always relative to a cultural situation. Fludernik (1996) situates the origin of natural narrative in the oral everyday discourse, the narrative that is the closest to our everyday experience. The more something is far from our everyday experience, the more unnatural it is. A gradation of distances can be outlined depending on the kind of actual world rule that is broken. For example, a logically unnatural story-world will be more unnatural than a physically unnatural one (Alber, 2009: 80). I argue that ontological metalepsis is the maximal distance that a narrative can have. Although the ontological boundary between fiction and reality is blurred, metalepsis 'ends up reasserting the existence of boundaries' (Ryan, 2004: 451), actualising the experience of Otherness.

In a poetic sense, the distance between the actual player and the game's world is the distance to the Moon, as the Othering of a distant World. The Moon belongs to the same space as the mythical, the imaginal, or the daydream, it 'is not a place of this world (which correlates to the realm of *historia*, narratives of fact), nor yet is it an entirely imaginary place like other spaces in

True Stories' (Ni Mheallaigh, 2020: 236). Different fictional travels to the Moon echo the travels to fictional space, especially to the sphere of games (Schenkel 2022). Jules Verne's *De la Terre à la Lune* (1966) showcases two possible worlds on the Moon—as in Burroughs's space (1986)—: either the American civilizing conquest or the travel to the absurd (Schenkel 2022, 301) embodied by the Frenchman. I argue that the distance necessary to travel to a game is the same as the one to the Moon. It is either the minimal distance, the equation of reality with fiction, the American conquest of fiction, or the maximal distance, the absurd travel to space.

> The distance from the game allowing the contingency is also the player's herself with what she does. … It is a *distanciation* doubled by a derealisation: the player who knows that she plays loses contact with reality. There is an illusion of 'game', meaning there is an entry into the game. (Bonenfant, 2013: 3; my emphasis)

2.2. Metaleptic Avatars

I regroup unnatural, 'boundary-skipping' (Wilson, 2000: 210) devices under the adjective metaleptic. Metalepsis, in its most general acceptation, is 'the transgression of boundaries which, in principle, are inviolable in narratives' (Pier, 2014: 331). Metalepsis creates an 'unacceptable and insistent hypothesis that the extradiegetic is perhaps always diegetic and that the narrator and his narratees—you and I—perhaps belong to the same narrative' (Genette, 1980: 236). Although its most commonly used sense is a transgression of one narrative layer to another (Genette, 2004), video games tend to be naturally *ontologically* metaleptic (see Bell, 2016). As such they are considered metaleptic machines (Ryan, 2004) and the avatar can be considered the 'metaleptic operator' (Genette, 2004: 110; Delbouille and Barnabé 2018). Understanding video games as second-person narration nuances the role of the avatar as the sole metaleptic operator—by dividing it into avatar, fictional subjectivity, and player—and allows a more detailed account of video games' potential to provoke wonder.

In its most obvious form, second-person narration is present in textual adventure games as the written 'you'. This abstract 'you' is the interface between the actual player and the game and can be in itself considered the avatar. Depending on who is addressed through this 'you', the narrative layers are separated on different levels. In a traditional adventure game like *The Legend* *of Zelda* (Nintendo R&D4, 1986), other characters address Link, the protagonist and player's avatar. In this case, the player's fictional subjectivity, the avatar, and the protagonist make one—the players would be more likely to say 'I died' than 'Link died'. In the case of life simulator games like *The Sims* (Maxis, 2000), the protagonist is separated from the player, creating an ontological separation between the Sims and the player with her cursor—the minimal form of the avatar. During game tutorials, the player temporarily becomes the protagonist, the addressee of the game and it is admitted by the game that the avatar is the player's puppet—a situation also happening in 'Thank you for playing' messages. Finally, a game like *Wonder Project J* (Almanic Co., 1994) creates its own category, as a life simulator that transforms the usual mouse cursor into a character, a robot fairy named Tinker, that is both aware of the player and of the virtual pet named Pino. Tinker embodies the ambivalent ontological and ethical situation of the avatar, both addressing the player and the protagonist, controlled by the actual player and controlling the virtual character.

The separation of the player from her avatar-protagonist happens if there is a dissociation between the two of them without the game acknowledging the player's existence. In this case, it is closer to a third-person narration—more common in books than in games. The transfer of agency from the player to the avatar, the identification of the player with her character, and the cybernetic embodiment provided by the avatar-in-the-world are game design choices that are prominent in the industry's pursuance of immersive games. Immersion is here to be understood as what allows players to close the critical distance towards the game to accept its logic as natural. The player immersed in a game is the equivalent of the human in her 'natural standpoint' in the actual world. As such immersion is the necessary first step for triggering wonder.

For the player, the death of the avatar is a crucial element concerning her identification with or dissociation from it. Whereas the cyclical temporary death of the avatar preserves the player's linear time perception, the definitive death of the avatar reminds the player's relative immortality and thus ontological distinction. For example, whereas 'I', the player-avatar-protagonist, died multiple times during my playthrough of *Red Dead Redemption 2* (Rockstar Studios, 2018), Arthur Morgan only dies at the end of the adventure. Before delving into the superposition of temporalities, the following paragraphs first address the uncanny effect provoked by the relationship between the living player and the dead avatar.

The uncanny relies on an inversion of the ontological situation between the Other and the Self leading to a realisation that the Self and the Other belong to the same World. This phenomenon already has been observed by Borges (1964) through the analysis of the relationship between the audience and the fictional characters:

> Why does it make us uneasy to know that the map is within the map and the thousand and one nights are within the book of A Thousand and One Nights? Why does it disquiet us to know that Don Quixote is a reader of the Quixote, and Hamlet is a spectator of Hamlet? I believe I have found the answer: *those inversions suggest that if the characters in a story can be readers or spectators, then we, their readers or spectators, can be fictitious*. In 1833 Carlyle observed that universal history is an infinite sacred book that all men write and read and try to understand, and in which they too are written (Borges, 1964: 46; my emphasis).

The definition of the uncanny has been explored and enriched throughout the 20th century through the scope of psychoanalysis. Still, we can find some fundamental elements shared with the definition of the avatar. Firstly, the uncertainty that one has about the definition of an object, especially related to its life status and the experience produced (Royle, 2008: 1). The uncanny creates 'doubts whether an apparently animate being is really alive; or conversely, whether a lifeless object might not be in fact animate' (Jentsch, 1906 cited in Freud, 2003: 111). A foundation for this theory is the short novel 'The Sandman' (Hoffman, 2024) in which a character, Nathanael, is obsessively in love with a woman, Olimpia but she is later revealed to be an automaton, which turns Nathanael insane. While Freud’s analysis of the relationship between Nathanael and Olimpia casts uncanny doubt about the automaton, Liu (2010) argues that it is more revealing of 'Nathanael's fantasies about himself being an automaton' (Liu, 2010: 220), an of Othering of the Self. This interpretation is closer to the transformative power of the avatar: it is not only the 'combination of life and lifelessness' (Kirkland, 2009: 1-2) but also

> the cybernetic interaction between player and machine, whereby the digital figure appears to act as though imbued with life, and the player appears to become more machine-like, unsettl[ing] the boundaries between dead object and living person (Kirkland, 2009: 2).

The uncanny relies first on a process of *identification* where both subjectivities are lost to form a system—the cyborg—that will then be broken through a process of *dissociation* when the Self realises the ontologically troubling situation.

This cybernetic interaction is similar—if not identical—to Levinas's 'face-to-face' experience, happening when the Self experiences the Other, it is 'the opening of a relation with a presence that is not of this time' (Mazis, 2016: 107). Whereas Levinas argues that 'this time' is the earthly time, Merleau-Ponty argues that it is only the Self's time, and that '[r]ather than being released from time, we are more deeply enmeshed in the dense folding back of time upon itself as it is lodged within the sensible world' (Mazis, 2016: 107). In other words, the players' and the avatar's time are different and when they make one, the perception of time becomes a cyborg's perception, constituted by the player-avatar system. Both the player and the avatar are Othered by the uncanny human-machine system, bringing them closer to the World.

Players are habituated to live through time in a completely different manner when playing a video game, especially when it implies a lot of deaths and respawns; 'avatars differ from us through their ability to *live, die, and live again*.' (Rehak, 107; original emphasis). Using Eliade's (1949) terminology[2] there is a coexisting, yet contradicting perception of time when taken up from the avatar's and the player's perspective. Players tend to forget their linear historical situation when playing the game, not only through the *flow state* (Czicsckenmikahli, 1990) but also through identification with the avatar's perception.

Throughout *Le Mythe de L'Éternel Retour*, Eliade (1949) depicts two figures opposed by their conception of time. The first is mythical, based on repetition and associated with the avatar's perception, and the other is historical, based on irreversibility[3] and associated with the player. The mythical is based on the reproduction of the 'archetypal model' (Eliade, 1949: 19), which excludes from memory any event outside of it (Eliade, 1949: 127). As such, the time loop in which the avatar is trapped when dying and reviving devalues the player's time and preserves the continuity of the game's narrative branch. While the avatar 'through this repetition lives ceaselessly in the present' (Eliade, 1949: 129), the player has 'the power of out-running and of

[2] Although very controversed for its application on human societies, the theories developed by Eliade stay valuable for and overlap with my analysis of the avatar's phenomenology.
[3] Eliade uses the outdated terms 'archaic man' and 'modern man' which are here replaced by 'mythical' and 'historical'.

‘nihilating’ (‘*néantiser*’) which dwells within us and is ourselves' (Merleau-Ponty, 2006: 497). Only certain events are retained as the ‘history’ of the game, they are what players remember as irreversible, i.e., the progression from the left to the right side of the screen, unravelling the game’s world for the player. During the game, the avatar’s death is only temporary because it is irrelevant to the game’s myth. It becomes only relevant when it coincides with the end of the game, the eschatological myth’s culmination.

In Turner’s (1974) terms, every challenge of the game can be analysed as a miniature *rite de passage* where failure is on the margin of the myth and success is the threshold toward a new part of the world. The repetition of failure, the avatar’s death and resurrection loop, is liminal, it transforms the avatar, but it is liminoid, i.e., a marginal transformation, for the player who only temporarily abandons her temporality to flow through the game. The game itself is a *rite de passage* and constitutes a liminal space for the player because it enriches her with a new experience of the Other. Merleau-Ponty expresses this kind of transformation in a poetic style: 'All those we have loved, detested, known, or simply glimpsed speak through our voice' (Merleau-Ponty 1964: 19).

According to Schallegger’s taxonomy of avatar function (2017), players can identify with their avatar (reducing their distance) in three different aspects. For a *shell avatar*, the player's identification relies on the embodied, kinaesthetic relationship with the avatar, for it has no characterisation—its minimal form is a mouse cursor. For such an avatar, 'correspondence to embodied reality consists of a mapping not of appearance but of control' (Rehak, 2013: 107). At the other end of the spectrum, the *personality avatar* is 'their own pre-defined character with an individual and specific narrative background, aesthetic appearance, mechanical role and capabilities' (Schallegger, 2017: 45), shifting 'the experience towards a more emotional and intellectual one' (ibid.). A *role avatar* is situated between the shell and the role, inviting 'parts of the player’s personality into the virtual world' (ibid.).

3. *Inside*

In light of the previous section, it is possible to analyse phenomena of identification and distanciation through the mechanics operated by the uncanny, the temporalities and the avatar function. The following section attempts such an analysis of the game *Inside*.

3.1. General Presentation

In line with the cinematic platformer genre, as, for instance, *Prince of Persia* (Broderbund, 1989), *Another World* (Chahi, 1991), *Oddworld: Abe's Oddysee* (Oddworld Inhabitants, 1997), *Heart of Darkness* (Amazing Studio, 1998), or *Rainworld* (Videocult, 2017), *Inside* immerses the player in a horrific and hostile world where her avatar's life is virtually constantly threatened. What makes these games unique is that their avatars, despite the hostility of the fictional worlds, are designed to be weak, hard to control, and possible to kill in a wide range of ways. *Inside* starts in medias res: when the text of the title screen disappears, its background is revealed to be the start of the game and the avatar appears from the far left of the screen only able to go to the right. The game is in 2.5D, meaning that the avatar can move in a 2-dimensional space, but the game's world has depth from which other elements can come to the avatar's plane. Most of the information about the world is given as embedded, *silent narrative* but the player understands easily the strong symbols of an authoritarian system: the soldiers shoot on sight, there are people deported in military trucks, farms and nature are abandoned to the profit of a gigantic scientific facility whose main projects are a mind control system and a biological abomination looking like a massive amalgam of human bodies called 'the Huddle'.

In terms of mechanics, the game is played with directional keys and two buttons, one for grabbing and one for jumping, and all the nuances in the avatar's movement are contextual. For instance, the avatar walks cautiously when surrounded by guards but will run when pursued by dogs. The key mechanic that serves for puzzle-solving is the mind control machine, a power already present in *Abe's Oddysee* but without the mise en abyme proper to *Inside* that un-hierarchies the player and her avatar's power over the other entities of the game's world. The avatar can plug itself into electronic devices—the mind-control helmets—which allows it to take control of harmless zombie-like creatures who can, in turn, plug themselves into another mind-control device in a mise en abyme of vicarious bodies. The game presents two different endings; the first happens when the player controls the Huddle, to break through the scientific facility, destroying everything on its way and ending up dying in a last breath on the beach, the end of the map on the far right side of the screen. The second happens when the player finds all hidden collectables and unlocks a secret room towards the beginning of the game, under the abandoned farm, where she can unplug the central mind control machine and see her avatar fall on the ground. This ending reveals that it was part of this system and was controlled as much as it controlled the zombie-like creatures. This latter ending is opposed to the first one, for it is outside of the linear time and space of the game; the player can load a saved state at any point of the map already explored to find the different collectables, which are permanently saved in the game's memory as collected.

3.2. Analysis

The parallel that Gallagher (2017) draws between the flow state maintained by repetition and the player giving away agency to the machine can be re-established with *Inside's* repetitive deaths. As a cinematic platformer, *Inside* is characterised by a highly hostile world in which progress is meant to be difficult. If at first, it can be an off-putting design choice as it forces the player to make more effort to be immersed in the game but, once this effort threshold is attained, this distance travelled makes the player closer to the machine. It uses a traditional 'die-and-retry' design type—high difficulty, low punishment—making the avatar reappear quickly and close to the challenging section; it is a 'repetition that leads to embodiment' (Hansen, 2015: 57) in synchronisation with the machine's temporality.

Inside's avatar movement is more independent from the player's input than in a traditional platformer. Willumsen (2018) analyses this kind of avatar behaviour through *automated avatar action* and *character autonomy*. The former concerns the extent of the avatar's actions that are implicitly asked by the player, based on and forming avatar control conventions. The character autonomy also relies on the avatar's independent actions, but only the ones that are unexpected by the player and construct the avatar's personality. *Inside* alternates between automated avatar action and character autonomy, playing on the distance between the player's and the avatar's embodiment.

On another level of embodiment, one of *Inside's* core mechanics is that the avatar can control the bodies of other humanoid creatures of the game's world. The player's vicarious embodiment alternates between the first and the second degree, always directly controlling the avatar, but sometimes seeing her control transferred to a secondary vicarious body. The distance here concerns the player's degree of agency over her avatar; she gives *indirect* orders to bodies in the game—similar to *Wonder Project J*.

The two endings illustrate the processes of identification and dissociation with striking limpidity. In the first ending, the game world unfolds linearly, every challenge reduces the distance between the player and the avatar to the point they make one; and the avatar makes one with the mind-controlled creatures of the game, forming a powerful amalgam of body, a new entity that is neither itself nor the others who tragically dies on the right side of the world. This ending is foreshadowed by a diorama towards the end of the game showing the Huddle on the beach; it is the 'identity ending', destroying the dystopian world of *Inside* from the inside, as a cyborg. The second ending relies on the cyborg dissociation: it requires the player to non-linearly travel through the game's world—using the non-diegetic menu—to switch off the central mind control machine turning the avatar into a creature like the one it used to control and dissociating it from the player's control. The two endings spacially represent the liminality of the avatar and the player. The first, for the avatar, is at the edge of the game's world, on the right side of the screen and the second, for the player, is at the edge of the machine, on the screen and controller.

Politically, the two endings are purely revolutionary and evade potential fascist readings. *Inside* focuses on the transformative bottom-to-top movement without giving space for the formation of a new elite. The game is deprived of flags, discourse, and names, and when it comes to the time of revolution, the protagonist becomes the mass, making it impossible to transform the movement into a political party. Furthermore, the game's main figure is a child, unable to fight but given the power to lead the masses toward the top. The only opportunity for killing is given to the Huddle when confronting the CEO of the scientific facility, a choice without consequence on the game's ending. As such it is opposed to fascist pseudo-anti-system discourses reappropriating revolutionary movements, as analysed by Sand (1991), through a fascination for 'the energetic, disciplined life of a large party, which recognised only the most male maxims and was bent on action, conquest and war' (Drieu la Rochelle, 1943: 66).

Conclusion

Ultimately, the present paper attempts to explain the political role of ontological wonder. Like the many unsolvable but necessary contradictions implied by ontological borders, it is here a matter of explaining the inexplicable. Wonder is a way of bringing into existence what does not exist, a form of pure creation. This creation is achieved by letting go of the pre-conceived World and accepting wonder to create, constituting the basis of a relationship with the game that enables the player to be transformed. This requires a lot of imagination that needs to be trusted as the basis for hope.

Pavel defines the ultimate impoverishment of the imaginary through the concept of 'flat structure' (Pavel, 1986: 54):

> [T]hey allow for no alternative base or for any movement outside the given actuality and its constellation of possibilities. … Seen from an external perspective, a flat structure is therefore a model representing the attitude of a population entirely deprived of the faculty of imagination. As things stand, a population deprived of imagination is but one person's fantasy in a population endowed with imagination. (Pavel, 1986: 55)

Such a society is a dead system where time no longer exists because there is only one great causal relationship, one great mythical cycle or eschatology without historical temporality. Ontological wonder protects history, the power of human transformation, i.e., creativity, the emergent, and anti-structure.

That imaginary is political is not new but knowing the political effects of video games analysis can lead to new discussions and it needs in-depth knowledge of how imaginary works in the ambivalent world of games. Video games, compared to other media, have a peculiar relationship to reality and the body. Narrative analysis needs to draw on phenomenological experience, combined with political and ontological analysis, in order to move towards something new and promote a creative, revolutionary imaginary, as opposed to a society designed to reproduce itself and by autophagy heading straight for an empty, fascist and morbid imaginary.

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